leaders with ‘political classes’ about the party’s policies. It was already identified that this inability to inspire organizations with the party’s social vision was a major cause of the 2014 electoral debacle. Many of us in that meeting opined that conducting classes for public representatives might not be the most effective way to instil a social vision (India’s political class might not inspire a vision). It will require a different kind of effort (which fructified in the BJY). The NAC was a top-down experiment that brought welfare and concrete policy outcomes; the BJY is a bottom-up experiment, but has no policy outcomes.

If the Congress party plans to organize BJY 2.0, it will have to concretize its social vision into identifiable policy outcomes. It is around these policy promises formulated through interactions with the common people that the Congress should go on to contest in the 2024 general elections. BJY 2.0 should also focus on not only interacting with the common people, but also institutionalizing the modalities of those interactions into its organizational ethics. It should be as much about educating its own cadre as about bringing them closer to local social activists. These interactions could prove to be pretty effective in creating the new organizational ethics of working for a larger cause, putting cause over petty calculations, putting party above networking, and fighting elections for a social cause and not bereft of it. Congress organizations should be convinced that over a period of time, elections can also be won on the basis of a vision and ideas and idealism, and not just around electoral engineering, however important that might be. The Congress party could also toy with the idea of opening up its doors to include more activists in its own rank and file. And, most importantly, the Congress party needs to front-end a new generation of leaders to roll out a galaxy of ideological/social programmes to directly counter the RSS–BJP. For this the Congress party will have to show even more resolve to walk the talk. Given his commitment to ideological issues and reforming the party organization, Rahul Gandhi has a special role in fructifying this.

In my routine interactions with social activists, the question that keeps coming back is: Will the Congress make a difference if it comes to power in